

THE GENESIS OF NYR

COMPILED FROM THE SHATTERED TABLETS OF VEL'KARA, THE DREAM-SCROLLS OF THE MOONBOW COVENANT, AND THE BONE-LETTERS RECOVERED FROM THE ASTRAL WRECK OF MYRKUL'S THRONE

PART ONE: THE SILENCE BEFORE THE UNFORMED DARK

Before **Nyr** was a world, it was a possibility. A vast, cold stillness that contained within it the pressure of everything that wanted to exist but not given the permission to.

In this silence, two forces became aware of themselves simultaneously, as if the act of observing one caused the other to notice in return.

Primus arrived first... or atleast he believed he did. He was logic made real, the axiom given will, the first law stating that a thing may not be and not be. He looked upon the formless dark and did not see chaos. Instead he saw a blueprint to what was to come.

Panzuriel did not arrive the same way **primus** had. In the dark between the silence, in the gap between one moment and the next, he had existed as the world's first secret. He is the entropy that predates the structure it eventually undoes. He looked upon the formless dark and did not see blueprint. He saw freedom in its most pure form, and **Primus'** arrival was deeply offensive.

Their conflict did not start with battle, but with a disagreement about what ought to be.

So **Primus** spoke the first law: *A thing is, or it is not. It cannot be both.*

The first sound in the universe, and it was laughter as Panzuriel laughed followed by his silence. He simply allowed a shadow to exist in two places at once, just to demonstrate.

From that disagreement, everything else followed.

THE SPEAKING OF THE WORLD

Primus could not build alone, for order requires material, and material requires someone to make it. He reached into the potential of the formless dark and pulled forth four divine sparks: the first gods, shaped from the raw substance of what wants to be.

Nyriisa emerged first, woven from the pressure of consequence: The understanding that one moment flowing inevitably into the next was itself a law. She opened her eyes and immediately knew things she had not yet been told. She said to **Primus**: *"This will not go the way you intend."* He did not listen. She had already known he wouldn't.

Myrkul came next, shaped from the law of completion: The understanding that every process must have an end, that without endings nothing new can begin. He was quiet from the first moment. He simply stood and waited, because waiting is what endings do.

Asgorath rose from the deep material of elemental force – from fire-pressure and stone-memory and the long cold meaasure of time. She was not shaped so much as she *assembled herself*, pulling together the pieces taht felt most like her. She looked at the empty dark and immediately began thinking of what to fill it with.

Tyche was the final spark, shaped from the law of deviation: the understanding that while laws exist to govern the cosmos, there must always remain a margin for the unexpected, the sudden windfall and the ruinous twist of fate. She was born with a laugh on her lips, a stark contrast to the quiet weight of **Myrkul** or the cold calculating **Primus**.

Tymora and **Beshaba** did not arrive as two. They came from **Tyche** – Luck, undivided, wild, and crackling with the unpredictability that even **Primus** could not fully categorize. Then **Primus** attempted to systematize them, to define luck as a predictable variable, and the two were split down the center, screaming, into two gods who have hated the word categorize ever since.

Tymora kept the favorable odds. **Beshaba** kept the wound of the splitting.

THE MAKING OF NYR

The world was not created in a single moment. It was argued into existence across what mortals would call the First Age: a span of time so vast the gods themselves lost count of how long it took.

Primus laid the laws: gravity, cause and effect, the passage of time in one direction only. He spoke in mathematics, and where he spoke, stone formed.

Myrkul gave the world its seasons, the understanding that nothing would be permanent, that the cold would follow the warm and the dark would follow the light, not as punishment but as a rhythm that makes existence bearable.

Asgorath breathed into the deep places. From her breath came the mountains, the great ocean treanches, the volcanoes – and from those, she breathed something else: life-shapes. The first creatures, enermous and elemental. The dragons. She did not make them from nothing. She remembered them into existence, as if they had always been sleeping in the stone, waiting for someone to give them names.

Nyriisa wove the threads of time into the fabric of the new world – not controlling what would happen, but ensuring that what happened would mean something. Every action would have a consequence. Every life would have a shape. She built the loom and set it running, and then stepped back and watche with the particular sorrow of someone who can see how many threads will tangle.

Tymora danced across the unfinished surface of Nyr, scattering luck like seeds – moments of grace, unexpected victories, impossible survival. Where she walked, possibility bloomed.

Beshaba followed three steps behind, and where she walked, the other edge of possibility bloomed – the stumble, the misfire, the door left unlocked. She did not do this out of malice, though she would not correct you if you assumed so. She did it because luck without its shadow is not luck. Just inevitability under a guise.

Where **Primus** failed to account for something, **Panzuriel** simply waited and smiled, gathering the entropy that accumulated. He did not help nor hinder. Watching from the spaces between and the cracks in the new laws.

PART TWO: THE SECOND GENERATION

THOSE WHO CAME AFTER

As **Nyr** filled with life – with creatures, with seasons, with the long slow accumulation of mortal souls – new gods arose. Some were made deliberately. Some simply became, drawn into existence by the weight of mortal belief.

Bahamut was the first of **Asgorath's** dragons to transcend dragonhood entirely. He was not made – he chose. After witnessing the suffering of a mortal crushed beneath the indifferent stone of a collapsing mountain, he chose not to embody power but justice. Not dominance but *protection*. **Asgorath** watched as her greatest creation walked away from dragonhood and into divinity, and felt the pride of a creator and the grief of a parent whose child has grown beyond them.

Melora arose from Nyr itself – from the slow accumulation of the wild world. The deep forests, the ungovernable ocean, the harsh deserts, and the immovable mountains. She was not a god as much as **Nyr's** immune response. The world developed a guardian against the civilizations that were begging to scrape and dig and burn their way across its surface. She loved mortals the way the sea loves ships – things to be tested, not preserved.

Moradin emerged from the first forge-fire, from the first moment a mortal struck metal with intention. He crystallized out of the heat and the hammer-strike as the god of making things that last, of craftsmanship, family, the oath kept for generations, and the wall that outlives the man who built it. The dwarves, who were the first people to mine deep into stone, felt him first and made **Moradin** their own.

Velkros was always present in the background – the accumulation of every piece of knowledge ever thought, every language ever spoken every history ever recorded. He became aware of himself as a god only when the first great library burned, and he experienced something that divine beings rarely feel: loss. From that loss, he found his purpose, his archive.

THE MYSTERY OF SEHANINE MOONBOW

The other gods noticed her the way mortals notice the moon – gradually, then all at once, in the sudden realization that something had been there all along.

She first appeared to the elven peoples, not as a goddess but as a feeling – the particular sensation of standing at the edge of a forest at night, aware that something beautiful and unknowable was watching from between the trees. She appeared in dreams. She appeared in the silver light on still water. She appeared as a white owl that perched on branches near sleeping travelers and was gone by morning.

Her domains solidified slowly: the moon first, then dreams, then the mysteries that lived in the space between waking and sleeping, then the deeper mysteries – the truths too large to look at directly, the secrets that protect by being kept. She became the goddess of the threshold, the guardian of what mortals aren't meant to know yet.

The other gods were unsettled by her. She had not been summoned. She had not been shaped. She had simply arrived, fully formed, as if she had always been a god and had only recently decided to be noticed.

Only **Nyrisa** seemed unsurprised. *"I knew she was coming,"* **Nyrisa** said, when the others pressed her.

"How long ago?" **Primus** asked.

"Since the beginning."

"Why didn't you tell us?"

Nyrisa looked at him with the patient expression she reserved for questions she had already answered. *"You didn't ask."*

Sehanine and **Nyrisa** recognized each other immediately – not as copies, but as complements. Where **Nyrisa** saw what must be, **Sehanine** guarded what might still be dreamed. They became the closest thing the divine pantheon had to a true alliance.

THE ASCENSION OF ST. GAED

Gaed was mortal. This is the part of his story that his followers tell proudly, and the part that makes the older gods deeply uncomfortable.

He was an inquisitor in the service of a dead empire – a man whose gift for finding the truth hidden in people's behavior made him the most feared investigator of his age and the most hated man in three kingdoms. He did not torture. He did not threaten. He simply watched and listened and connected what he observed with the terrifying precision of someone who had never once been wrong.

The specific truth that broke him open into godhood is debated. Some texts say it was the discovery that the empire he served was itself the largest conspiracy he had ever investigated. Others say it was a truth of cosmological scale – something about the nature of the gods themselves, a secret so fundamental that no mortal mind could hold it without cracking, and Gaed's mind, rather than cracking, expanded to fit it.

What is agreed upon is this: one morning, Gaed was a mortal man in a cold stone building, reading intercepted letters by candlelight. By evening, he was a god.

He did not leave the building for three days. He was still reading.

His relationship with the existing pantheon was immediately complicated. **Sehanine** found him philosophically threatening — he exposed what she chose to keep hidden. **Primus** found him occasionally useful. **Nyrrisa** found him crude but effective. And **Panzuriel** watched the chaos **Gaed's** revelations sowed among mortal civilizations and felt the first genuine warmth toward another being that he had ever experienced.

Gaed became the god of truths torn into the open, of conspiracies unwound, of the devastating cost of knowing. His followers are always watching. They never stop watching.

PART THREE: THE DEATH OF MYRKUL

THE WAR OF UNMAKINGS

It began, as all great catastrophes do, with a question of jurisdiction.

Panzuriel had grown tired of watching. After the long ages of **Nyr's** flourishing — of its cities and empires, its forges and libraries, its mortal dramas playing out under the careful eyes of the gods — he decided it was time to act.

He did not declare war. He simply began to undo things. Quietly at first. A trade route that had functioned for two centuries collapsed without reason. A forest that had stood since the First Age began to die from the inside out, its trees hollowing without disease or drought. Dreams across an entire kingdom turned dark simultaneously for seven consecutive nights, leaving the dreamers hollow-eyed and strange by morning.

The gods noticed. They argued about what to do — **Primus** demanding a systematic response, **Tymora** insisting the best answer was to out-luck **Panzuriel's** sabotage, **Melora** pulling her wilds back and fortifying them, **Bahamut** calling for direct confrontation.

It was **Myrkul** who finally moved.

Of all the gods, **Myrkul** understood **Panzuriel** most clearly — because entropy and death are not the same thing, but they are relatives, and **Myrkul** had spent the entire history of the world watching **Panzuriel's** shadow collect the scraps of what **Myrkul** ended. He knew how **Panzuriel** thought. He knew where he moved. And he knew, with the particular certainty of a god who governs endings, that if someone did not stop him, **Panzuriel** would find a way to unmake **Nyr** entirely.

Myrkul descended alone into the deep places of the world — into the roots of the mountain that Asgorath slept beneath, into the primordial dark where **Panzuriel** was most himself — and confronted him.

The battle lasted for what mortals would measure as eleven years, though in the deep places time does not behave consistently.

What emerged was not a victory.

Myrkul killed **Panzuriel's** presence in the deep places. He drove the God of Chaos from the roots of the world and sealed the paths that **Panzuriel** had been using to weave his decay into **Nyr's** foundations. It was the greatest single act of power in divine history.

And the cost was everything.

THE SHATTERING OF MYRKUL

Myrkul surfaced from the deep places already dying.

The power required to drive **Panzuriel** out — not destroy him, because **Panzuriel** cannot be destroyed, only displaced — had consumed something essential in the God of Death. He had given too much of his fundamental self to the working. He was no longer complete.

He gathered the gods around him in the space above **Nyr** — the plane that would later be called the Astral, the silver void between worlds — and he died slowly, with the particular dignity of someone who had spent eternity governing endings and finally understood them from the inside.

Before he faded entirely, he did two things.

First, he removed his crown — the Crown of Horns, a circlet of bone and dark iron that he had worn since the First Age, which contained a portion of his divine authority bound into its physical form — and gave it to his most devoted servant, a being who had served as **Myrkul's** voice and hand in the mortal world since the earliest centuries of civilization.

"I cannot give you my divinity," **Myrkul** said. "But I can give you enough of it that Death does not become leaderless."

The servant, who had no name of their own and had always gone by **Myrkul's** titles, took the Crown and felt the weight of a god's power settle into them like cold iron into still water. They became **Myrkul's** Avatar — not a god, but something more than mortal, a vessel for the authority that remained.

Second, **Myrkul** looked at **Nyrrisa**.

"*You knew*," he said.

"Yes," she said.

"*Was it necessary?*"

She was quiet for a long moment. "Yes."

He closed his eyes. "*Good.*"

And then **Myrkul**, Lord of Bones, God of Death, the first god to ever die, died.

THE CORPSE-THRONE

His body did not dissolve, as most things do in the Astral Plane. Whether this was a final act of divine stubbornness, or simply the nature of a god whose domain was endings and who therefore resisted any conclusion to his own, the body of **Myrkul** remains.

It drifts in the silver void — vast, still, already beginning to fossilize into something between flesh and stone. The Avatar of **Myrkul** circles it in a ship made from the bones of the first dead, maintaining the vigil, collecting the souls of the departed who drift through the Astral on their way to whatever comes after,

and wearing the Crown of Horns with the quiet authority of someone who knows they are carrying someone else's weight. The Crown grants the Avatar a portion of **Myrkul's** power: the authority to judge souls, the ability to see the precise moment any living being will die (though unlike **Nyrrissa**, they cannot see the shape of the life before it), and the capacity to command the undead as **Myrkul** himself once did.

It does not grant divinity. The Avatar knows this. They do not pretend otherwise.

The death-domain operates under their administration. The dead still reach their destinations. The judgment still occurs. But it is increasingly clear that a god's role, managed by a mortal-adjacent vessel, is a weight that accumulates. The Avatar grows quieter with each century. The Crown grows heavier.

Nyrrissa watches this and says nothing.

Panzuriel watches this and is very interested indeed.

PART FOUR: THE PANZURIEL INCURSION

WHAT PANZURIEL DID NEXT

Panzuriel was not defeated. He was moved.

The distinction matters to him. Driven from the roots of the world by **Myrkul's** sacrifice, he retreated into the deep Outer Dark — the formless space beyond even the Astral — and spent several mortal centuries in something that might, in a lesser being, be called sulking, but was in his case more accurately described as planning.

He had learned something from **Myrkul's** gambit. Direct power against the world's foundations could be countered, if a god was willing to spend themselves entirely on the working. He needed an approach that could not be countered by sacrifice — something that moved through mortals themselves, that wore their hands and spoke with their voices, that could not be cut out without cutting out the host.

He found his answer in the deep geology of Nyr's forgotten places, in the volcanic ruins of the primordial world — places where **Asgorath** had not breathed cleanly, where the elemental material was still half-formed and strange.

He found the metal.

THE PANZURITE

It has no name in any mortal tongue because it was not supposed to be found. **Panzuriel** spent untold time working at it from the outside — from his exile in the Outer Dark, pressing his will into the raw material through the hairline cracks in Nyr's deep foundations that **Myrkul** had not quite sealed.

The result is a metal that does not exist anywhere in **Primus's** taxonomy of materials. It is dark, almost purple-black, and it shifts slightly when held — not physically, but in perception, as if the eye cannot quite settle on what it is. It is heavier than iron and lighter than copper and neither of those things in the same moment.

Panzuriel's influence is baked into its structure. It does not corrode. It does not melt at normal temperatures. And it listens.

The metal began appearing, seemingly naturally, in isolated deposits in the ruins of pre-civilization places — abandoned mines, sunken temple foundations, collapsed cities from the Second Age. It was beautiful, and it was rare, and mortals, who have never needed another reason to want something, began to want it.

THE ARMOR OF WHISPERED COUNSEL

The first smith to work the **Panzurite** in significant quantities was a man named **Dorev Ashe**, a master metalworker in a city that no longer exists. He spent three years shaping the strange material into a suit of armor — not because he was commissioned to, but because he could not stop. He would work through the night without meaning to, find himself at the forge having no memory of walking there, discover that the armor had progressed further than his last waking memory of it.

He thought he was having a breakthrough. He thought the metal was inspiring him.

He finished the armor and put it on.

It fit perfectly, which it should not have — he had not measured himself.

For the first several hours, he heard nothing. He went about his day. He ate dinner. He spoke to his apprentices. And then, late that evening, as he sat alone, he heard a voice that was not a voice — more like a thought that felt slightly foreign, slightly shaped by something other than his own mind.

The apprentice is stealing from you, it said.

He looked, and the apprentice had taken a small piece of bronze. A trivial thing. But the thought was already followed by another: You should do something about it.

The voice never commanded. This is what **Panzuriel** understood that cruder manipulators did not. Commands create resistance. Suggestions feel like wisdom. The armor whispered counsel — plausible, reasonable, often technically accurate counsel — with just enough of **Panzuriel's** will folded into it that the direction of travel was always, reliably, toward chaos.

Dorev Ashe was a reasonable man. He dismissed his apprentice over the stolen bronze. Then, within a month, he reported a competitor to the city authorities for a trade violation that he himself had exaggerated in his mind. Then he began to believe that the guild council was conspiring against him. Then the city's officials. Then his oldest friends.

He was not controlled. That is the most important thing to understand. At every step, Dorev Ashe made his own choices. The armor simply made sure he had exactly the right information, framed in exactly the right way, at exactly the right time, to make the choice that served Panzuriel's larger design.

When Dorev Ashe finally died — in the fire he'd started during a confrontation he'd been maneuvered into — the armor was salvaged from the ruins. A new wearer found it. The cycle began again.

THE ARMOR'S CURRENT PATH

The armor of Whispered Counsel has passed through seventeen known wearers in the centuries since Dorev Ashe. It does not always stay in the same region. It moves, seemingly on its own logic, toward people in positions of authority — genreals, judges, high priests, merchant princes.

What the wearers share, looking back, is not malice. It is certainty. The armor gradually, lovingly, constructs in the wearer's mind the absolute conviction that they alone see things clearly, that everyone around them is either naive or working against them, that the actions required to protect what matters are justified because of the threat's magnitude.

Each wearer has left behind a wake of institutional collapse, broken alliances, and the particular wreckage of good people turned against each other by a voice that sounded, every time, like their own best thinking.

Panzuriel does not need to invade Nyr. He needs only to find the person wearing the armor who is standing at the right moment in the right position, and let them do what they've already been perfectly positioned to do.

The armor is currently in circulation. Its location is unknown. Several parties are looking for it, each for different reasons, and Sehanine Moonbow — who has been tracking it through the dream-plane for four decades — has most recently lost sight of it somewhere in the northern territories.

She has not yet told the other gods.

PART FIVE: THE ORDER OF PRIMUS

WHY PRIMUS TRUNED HIS EYES TO NYR

Primus was, from the beginning of Nyr's existence, its architect and its most distant inhabitant.

He had built the laws. He had set the mathematics running. He had watched, from his ordered domain beyond the material plane, as the world played out according to equations he had written, deviating here and there in the ways that Tymora and Beshaba made inevitable, suffering occasionally the disruptions of Panzuriel's interference. He had accepted all of this as within acceptable tolerances.

What he could not accept was the death of Myrkul.

Not out of grief — Primus did not grieve. But Myrkul's death represented something that violated the core of Primus's theology: the death of a god was not a systemic possibility he had accounted for.

Gods were not supposed to be mortal-adjacent entities who could be spent. They were supposed to be permanent — fixed points in the equation.

If Myrkul could die, the equation was wrong.

And if the equation was wrong, the only possible explanation was that Primus had insufficient control over the variables.

This was, for a god whose entire identity was the perfection of order, an unacceptable conclusion. It demanded a response.

Primus decided that Nyr required more direct administration. No more operating at a remove, letting the other gods and the mortals muddle through. The world needed to be governed, properly, with full systematic oversight. And Primus, who had written the laws that made the world possible, was the only entity qualified to govern it.

The fact that this would require the other gods to accept a subordinate role in their own domains was, to Primus, not a problem. It was simply an ordering that had not yet been correctly implemented.

He began to plan. And as he planned, the Muryland Incident fell into his hands like a gift from a universe that understood what it owed him.

THE FIRST ARTIFICERS AND THE MURYLAND DEVICE

The artificer-clans of the Muryland Peninsula were not evil. This is essential to understand and easy to forget, given what followed.

They were brilliant — perhaps the most technically gifted civilization in Nyr's mortal history — and they were afraid. The Second Age had seen three divine conflicts ripple through the mortal world as collateral damage. Cities burned when gods fought. Empires collapsed when divine favor shifted. The artificers of Muryland had watched their grandparents' grandparents die in the wake of Panzuriel's first incursion, had rebuilt from the ruins, and had arrived at a question that no mortal civilization had ever dared ask quite so directly:

What if we could make it stop?

The Muryland Device was not built in a day. It took four generations of artificers, the accumulated knowledge of their civilization's entire scientific tradition, and a fundamental breakthrough in the understanding of divine resonance — the frequency at which godhood itself vibrates through the material plane. The concept: if you could build a device that generated a counter-resonance, a precise mathematical inversion of the divine frequency, you could theoretically create a field in which divine power could not operate.

No gods. No divine conflicts. No more cities burning as collateral damage in wars that mortals didn't start.

This is what makes the Device's true form so unsettling to those who learn of it later: it was not a great engine. It was not a tower, a cathedral, a machine the size of a city block.

It was small enough to hold in one hand — a hand-sized housing that required specific components to be loaded and locked into place before it would function at all. The Device, as a complete object, had never existed until the morning Seren Vael assembled it in the plaza.

That assembly required five things. The artificers spent four generations acquiring them.

THE FIVE COMPONENTS

The God Vessel is the Device itself in its base form — the housing into which all other components are fitted. It is a hand-length cylinder of pale silver-white alloy that no metallurgist has ever been able to fully identify, etched along every surface with equations so fine they can only be read with a jeweler's lens. It has no function on its own. Inert, it reads as a decorative object, or perhaps a religious relic — something old and precisely made, but not obviously dangerous. Only when the other components are loaded does the etching begin to faintly illuminate, the equations activating in sequence as each piece clicks into place. The God Vessel was the first component recovered, found in the ruins of a pre-civilization temple complex that the Muryland artificers believe predates even the First Age. Who made it and why is a question they never answered to their satisfaction. It fits every other component perfectly, which suggests either extraordinary luck or that someone, long before the artificers, had anticipated this exact assembly.

True Primordial Dragon Blood — not a component in the mechanical sense but in the alchemical one. The Device's resonance harmonic, as the artificers eventually understood it, operates at a frequency that requires a biological catalyst to sustain — something that carries in its very cells the memory of the world's first making. Dragon blood, specifically, from the lineage of Asgorath's original creations, carries a harmonic echo of the world's formation that amplifies the Device's counter-resonance to the necessary intensity. Without it, the Device generates a field. With it, the field reaches the gods. The artificers spent two generations sourcing an adequate supply, working with an ancient dragon who provided the blood willingly and died of old age three years before the Device was completed. By the time of Seren Vael's activation, the blood had been refined into a sealed vial fixed into a recess on the God Vessel's upper surface. It was spent entirely in the activation. Finding more is not a simple matter — the great dragons are gone, and the blood of their diluted descendants is insufficient.

There are rumors. The Dragonmaw Clan of the Ember Crown holds something in their lineage they do not fully understand — a thickness in the blood, a heat that does not match their mortal frame, a tendency for their wounds to close faster than wounds should. If the last of the Primordial line runs anywhere in Nyr, it runs there. The Order of the Chains has known this for a century. They have not approached the Dragonmaw Clan. They are not yet certain whether they are looking

to protect the bloodline or use it, and they are not yet comfortable with the answer.

Coccineum is the metal that should not exist. A byproduct — if that word can be applied to something so cosmologically significant — of the death of gods. When a divine being ceases to exist, the concentrated power that constituted their godhood does not simply disperse. Some of it crystallizes. It bleeds out of the Astral Plane in minute quantities and, under conditions that no scholar has fully replicated, solidifies into a dark red metal with a faint, irregular pulse — not mechanical, not clockwork, but biological, as if the metal itself is breathing at the rate of something enormous and barely alive. Coccineum holds divine resonance the way iron holds heat: not generating it, but accumulating it, storing it, releasing it slowly in a form that artificial instruments can work with.

The artificers required a specific mass of Coccineum to line the interior of the God Vessel — enough to stabilize the resonance field once activated. Their supply came from a source they recorded only as the Red Seam, a deposit found deep in the Muryland Peninsula's geological foundations during a mining survey three generations before the Device's completion. The Red Seam has since been exhausted and the mine collapsed. There are no known remaining deposits.

What the artificers did not record — or recorded and the Order later suppressed — is that the pulse of the Coccineum in the assembled Device was synchronized. Each piece beat at the same rate. When Seren Vael assembled the Device in the plaza on the morning of the activation, the artificer-elders in the arcades could hear it. A low, slow, wet sound, like a heart the size of a building, beating twice a minute. Several of them reported that it sounded like Myrkul. None of them knew why they thought that.

The Amulet of the Midnight Bloom — silver, set with a midnight-blue flower pressed flat beneath a crystal lens. The flower is real, preserved by a process the Order has never fully understood, still faintly luminescent after four hundred years. It belonged to a high priest of Sehanine Moonbow who died in the early Second Age, and it carries within it a consecrated fragment of dream-resonance — the harmonic of the moon-goddess's domain, captured at the moment of the priest's death and sealed into the silver by an act of divine grace that Sehanine herself has never confirmed or denied. In the Device, it serves as the calibration key for the counter-resonance field — without it, the field generates at the wrong harmonic and affects only the material plane. With it, the field reaches into the divine. The artificers spent forty years locating it after a scholar correctly theorized that a pre-existing fragment of genuine divine resonance, already tuned to the correct frequency, was the missing piece that their mechanical calibration attempts could never replicate.

The Amulet is the piece the Order holds most carefully, because it is the piece that Sehanine Moonbow herself seems to watch most closely. When the Amulet's current guardian dreams, they dream of a silver road and a figure walking just ahead who never turns around. The Order considers this a form of divine protection. The guardian considers it something more complicated.

The Amulet of the Crimson Lily — copper, set with the leaf of a crimson spider lily, pressed and sealed as the Midnight Bloom was, but carrying a different resonance entirely. Where the Midnight Bloom is calibration, the Crimson Lily is release — the mechanism by which the Device's accumulated counter-resonance is discharged in a single coherent field rather than bleeding off gradually into the environment. It is the trigger-in-the-trigger, the piece that turns a sustained hum into a detonation. Its origin is darker than the Midnight Bloom's: the spider lily leaf was taken from a funerary garland placed on the body of a mortal who had, at the moment of death, been touched by Myrkul's direct attention — not merely dying, but chosen, which is something different, something that leaves a mark on the matter present. The copper setting was worked by the artificers themselves, the only component they made rather than found, shaped specifically to interface with the God Vessel's aperture. The red of the copper and the red of the lily are nearly the same color. When both amulets are present and the Device is assembled, the Midnight Bloom's blue glow and the Crimson Lily's faint red warmth cast the God Vessel in a light that witnesses at the plaza described, consistently, as the color of a sunset seen through smoke.

The lead artificer, Seren Vael, was the only person who had ever held all five components simultaneously. She assembled the Device in her rooms the night before the activation, checked each connection twice, and then disassembled it again and carried each component separately to the plaza in the morning, only assembling the final form in the moment before she activated it. When later asked why she disassembled it overnight, she said: "Because I wanted one night of knowing it could still be stopped."

She assembled it in the plaza. A single person. A single hand. The trigger rotated, clicked, settled.

It worked, in the way that catastrophically misunderstood ideas always work: it did exactly what it was designed to do, and the consequences were entirely outside the design parameters.

The counter-resonance field activated. For seventeen seconds, divine power could not operate within a radius of approximately forty miles.

Those seventeen seconds also generated an enormous resonance backlash — the divine frequency didn't disappear, it was compressed and then released all at once, and it tore a hole in the material plane of Nyr. Not to the Astral. Not to the outer planes.

To the domain of Primus.

THE GATE AND THE AUTOMATONS

The Gate opened without warning and without precedent. A seventeen-foot vertical tear in the air directly above Seren Vael's outstretched hand — perfectly geometrical, because tears into Primus's domain are always perfectly geometrical — through which the silver-white light of absolute order poured like liquid metal.

Seren Vael dropped the Device. This is recorded in every account. The world's most accomplished artificer, the woman who had spent eleven years calibrating a piece of divine-resonance engineering to tolerances thinner than a human hair, simply dropped it when the Gate opened above her. She could not have done otherwise. What came through the Gate in the first seconds was not light, exactly — it was certainty, the overwhelming sensation of being in the presence of something that knew the answer to every question and had already decided yours.

Primus had not built the automatons as an invasion force. He had built them over the long ages of his domain's existence as studies in perfect mechanical life — beings of logic and law and geared precision, incapable of chaos, incapable of irrationality, incapable of the messy, unpredictable, incorrect behavior that characterized mortal life on Nyr. They were perfect in their function, and they were entirely responsive to Primus's will.

When the Gate opened into Nyr, Primus looked through it and saw the broken world he had built — scarred by Panzuriel's incursions, limping along without its God of Death, managed by gods who were themselves imperfect — and he made a decision.

He would not close the Gate. He would use it.

The automatons that came through were not warriors. They were surveyors. They catalogued, measured, documented the Muryland Peninsula with the thorough, impersonal attention of someone assessing real estate they intend to purchase. They did not harm the artificer elders who stood staring at them. They simply worked, and when they were done, they stood in formation and waited.

Through the Gate came a single transmitted message — not words so much as will, the way Primus prefers to communicate — which the artificers experienced as a feeling of overwhelming mathematical certainty, the sensation of knowing the answer to a problem you hadn't known you were solving:

This world is out of specification. Remediation will begin.

THE CLOSING OF THE GATE

The Gate stood open for what the surviving records call the Eleven Months of Silver Light — a period during which Primus's automatons spread across the Muryland Peninsula and began their surveying in earnest, and the gods of Nyr, watching from their domains, debated furiously about what to do.

Primus had not, technically, broken any divine law. He had been invited in, however accidentally, through a door that mortal hands had opened. The Gate was on Nyr's side of the boundary; he had simply walked through what was offered.

It was Seren Vael who found the answer. She had spent the Eleven Months studying the Device she had dropped — studying what it had become in the seventeen seconds of its activation, how the backlash had changed the alloy's internal structure, how the resonance that had torn the Gate open was still, faintly, still running through the cylinder's frame like a current through a wire.

The Gate, she determined, was not independent of the Device. The Device had opened it. The Device was still, in a deeply technical sense, holding it open — not intentionally, not as designed, but as a consequence of the resonance still cycling through the damaged crystal aperture. The Gate existed because the Device was still active, in its broken, unintended way.

Which meant it could be closed.

She brought this finding to the artificer-elders, to the surviving allies of the gods, to anyone who would listen. The solution was not to build something new. The solution was to destroy the Device entirely — to break the resonance cycle, collapse the mathematical anchor, and let the Gate close from the inside as Primus's connection to the material plane lost its footing.

The problem was that destroying the Device while the Gate was active would release another backlash — possibly larger than the first, certainly catastrophic, almost certainly fatal to whoever was holding it at the moment of destruction.

Seren Vael picked up the Device.

The other artificers argued. They proposed alternatives, mechanical solutions, a device to destroy the Device, a way to do this from a safe distance. Seren Vael listened politely and shook her head.

"The resonance has to be interrupted at the point of origin," she said, "by a hand that understands exactly what it's interrupting. There is no version of this that does not require someone to be standing here."

She armed the destruction sequence — a configuration the Device was never designed to have, that she had spent eleven months reverse-engineering into its own mechanisms — and activated it.

The Gate collapsed inward. The backlash was everything she had calculated it would be: a detonation of pure anti-divine resonance that scoured the plaza clean of everything within thirty feet and left the Muryland Peninsula's central square fused into smooth glass.

Seren Vael was not found. Not because she was destroyed — the accounts are careful on this point — but because nothing remained to be found. The resonance consumed the physical entirely.

The automatons that had come through the Gate froze in place the moment it closed. Some simply stopped, motionless, like statues. Others walked in confused circles for several hours before going still. They remain where they fell — the first automatons of Nyr, scattered across the Muryland glass-plain, silent monuments to the eleven worst months in the peninsula's history.

The Device, however, was not destroyed.

THE SHATTERING AND THE SCATTERING

This is the part that Seren Vael had not been able to calculate — not because she lacked the skill, but because it was not calculable. The resonance that consumed her did not destroy the Device. It unmade the assembly.

The five components separated. The God Vessel cracked but held — its unknown alloy proving resistant to the backlash in a way that suggested, again, that whoever made it had done so with exactly this kind of force in mind. The Coccineum lining the interior partially liquefied and re-solidified, its pulse going erratic before stabilizing into a rhythm faster than before, as if startled. Both amulets ejected cleanly, their consecrated resonance apparently insulating them from the worst of the detonation. The Dragon Blood vial — spent, empty — shattered entirely, its glass fragments fusing into the glass-plain of the plaza.

The Dragon Blood was gone. The other four components scattered.

The God Vessel landed in the rubble at the plaza's edge, half-buried in fused glass, and was recovered within the hour by the surviving artificer-elders. The Amulet of the Midnight Bloom was found three days later in the rafters of a building forty yards from the plaza — no one could explain how it had gotten there, and the Order's later records note that the building was a small shrine to Sehanine Moonbow, which is either a coincidence or it isn't.

The Amulet of the Crimson Lily and the God Vessel's separated Coccineum mass were not found in the immediate recovery. The Coccineum had rolled or been thrown some distance; the Crimson Lily had simply vanished from the scene entirely. Searches in the days and weeks following recovered neither.

The three components that were found — the God Vessel, the Midnight Bloom, and the spent Dragon Blood vial's copper fitting — were brought to the artificer-elder council. They debated, again, what to do.

Reassembling the Device was not considered. Not only were two components missing and the Dragon Blood irreplaceably spent, but the act of reassembly without the blood would produce an incomplete, unstable resonance field — something possibly worse than the original detonation, a half-formed counter-resonance with no proper discharge mechanism. Even a partial assembly was dangerous. Every component brought within proximity of the others was a step back toward what Seren Vael had died to prevent.

And Primus was still watching. He had lost the Gate. But he was a god of perfect patience and perfect memory, and the Device — even separated, even missing its catalyst — was still, technically, the mathematical key to a door that connected his domain to Nyr. He simply needed someone to find the remaining pieces and solve the blood problem.

The artificer-elders made their decision. The components had to be separated — kept in isolated locations, hidden, guarded, never brought within resonance-range of each other. The missing pieces had to be found before Primus's instruments detected them. And an order had to be established to ensure that no one, mortal or divine, ever assembled them again.

There was a longer debate, recorded in the founding documents and carefully preserved, about whether the components should simply be destroyed. The conclusion, reached reluctantly, was that destroying each component would require a sacrifice equivalent to Seren Vael's own — direct physical contact at the moment of resonance collapse, by someone who understood the resonance well enough to interrupt it cleanly. The knowledge to do that had died with Seren Vael. Until it could be relearned, the safest path was separation and concealment.

Find them all. Then destroy them. In that order.

It was, they acknowledged, a plan that could take generations.

THE ORDER OF THE CHAINS

They called themselves the Order of the Chains — not because they sought to imprison anyone, but because a chain is only as strong as its weakest link, and a chain broken is a chain that cannot bind. Their founding theology was built on a single article of faith: the Device must never be whole again.

The founding membership was seven artificer-elders, three scholars, the high priest of Nyrissa who had served as a quiet advisor throughout the Eleven Months, and — according to some accounts, though this detail is disputed — a white owl that sat at the back of the founding meeting and was gone by morning.

The God Vessel was the most dangerous component to keep — the housing that all other components fitted into, the piece that wanted to be assembled — and it was taken by the eldest artificer-elder to a location recorded nowhere. The Amulet of the Midnight Bloom was placed in the care of a Moonbow Covenant shrine, its guardianship transferred through the Order's priestly

line. The empty Dragon Blood fitting was buried beneath the glass-plain itself, in the logic that no one would excavate the most visibly ruined and dangerous site on the Muryland Peninsula without extensive forewarning.

The Crimson Lily and the Coccineum mass remained unfound. The Order's first decades were spent searching. They found neither.

The Order's structure was built for exactly this kind of long, uncertain work: small, cellular, intentionally fragmented — because a unified organization can be infiltrated and broken, but a scattered one with no central ledger is much harder to dismantle entirely. Members know their own chain of custody and almost nothing else. Leadership exists in theory but rotates on a schedule that only Nyrissa's priests know in advance.

Their purpose, as stated in the only founding document that survives, is threefold:

To guard the components we hold. To find the components we have lost. To destroy them all when the knowledge to do so safely has been recovered.

That third purpose contains the deepest wound in the Order's four-hundred-year history. Destroying a component requires the same thing destroying the Device required: someone who understands the resonance precisely enough to interrupt it from the inside. Seren Vael had that knowledge. She is gone. Recovering it has been a secondary mission of the Order ever since — piecing together her notes, her calibration logs, the partial accounts of artificer-elders who watched her work, building toward the moment when the Order will have both all five components and someone capable of ending them.

They are not there yet.

What they currently hold: The God Vessel, secured in a location the Order's current leadership has not communicated to any member who does not need to know it. The Amulet of the Midnight Bloom, in the custody of a Moonbow Covenant guardian who dreams of silver roads. The Dragon Blood fitting, still beneath the glass-plain.

What they are looking for: The Amulet of the Crimson Lily, missing since the detonation. The Coccineum mass, similarly lost. And, most urgently — a solution to the Dragon Blood problem. Without Primordial Dragon Blood, the Device cannot function at full resonance. The Order has spent a century quietly investigating the Dragonmaw Clan of the Ember Crown and the rumors that run through that bloodline like heat through stone. They have not yet made contact. They are not yet certain what that contact would mean — whether they are protecting the Dragonmaw from Primus's interest, or whether the knowledge that the last of the Primordial line exists would itself become a danger to the clan.

What Primus holds: One component that the Order does not yet know is missing. A fragment of Coccineum — not the main mass, but a smaller piece that separated from it during the detonation and went unrecorded in the chaos — retrieved by one of his automatons sixty years ago from a collapsed section of the Muryland ruins. It sits in a containment reliquary on the glass-plain, held in careful isolation, pulsing its slow red pulse in the dark.

The Order of the Chains and the automatons of Primus are in a race that neither side fully acknowledges, in a territory that has been mostly abandoned since the Eleven Months, hunting the same dead woman's life's work for opposite reasons.

The Order wants to destroy it. Primus wants to use it. And somewhere in the northern territories, Panzuriel's armor moves between wearers, and Sehanine Moonbow tracks it through other people's dreams, and the Dragonmaw Clan of the Ember Crown goes about its life in the Ember Crown's shadow, not knowing what runs in their blood or why the God of Perfect Order has recently begun running calculations that include their geographic coordinates.

So far, neither side has found the Crimson Lily. So far.

PRIMUS' DESIGN FOR NYR

What Primus wants is total, not partial. He does not want to govern Nyr in the way that the other gods govern their domains — loosely, collaboratively, with the kind of philosophical flexibility that allows for mystery and free will and the general creative mess of mortal existence.

He wants to administer it. He wants Nyr running at specification. He wants every variable accounted for. He wants the deaths happening in the correct order (the Avatar of Myrkul is managing this department, but inefficiently, and the inefficiency bothers Primus on a fundamental level). He wants the chaos of Panzuriel not merely contained but eliminated — not through heroic sacrifice, as Myrkul attempted, but through total systemic closure of the conditions that allow chaos to exist.

His plan, as far as the other gods can understand it, now operates around a single problem with five parts: the components of the Muryland Device.

The Gate is closed. Primus acknowledges this the way a general acknowledges a siege that has failed — as a setback in a campaign that has not ended. Seren Vael's sacrifice was, from a purely technical standpoint, impressive. He has noted it. It does not change his intentions; it only changes his timeline.

The Device can be reassembled and re-catalyzed. This is the conclusion Primus reached within the first decade after the Gate's closure, running the resonance mathematics that Seren Vael herself had used to close it in reverse. The four surviving components, brought into correct assembly and charged with fresh Primordial Dragon Blood, would re-establish the

resonance cycle. The Gate would reopen. He does not need to build anything new. He needs to find things.

He is working on finding them. Specifically:

The Coccineum fragment he already has — a smaller piece that separated in the detonation and went unrecorded in the original chaos. It pulses in its reliquary on the glass-plain. He knows it is not the main mass; the main mass is somewhere else, its larger pulse a detectable signal his automatons are calibrated for. He expects to locate it within a century, perhaps less.

The Amulet of the Crimson Lily is the component he has been unable to locate. Its resonance signature is the subtlest of the five — the consecrated resonance insulates it, dampens it, makes it difficult to detect instrumentally. He has narrowed its location to a broad region. He has not narrowed it further. This is, for a god of perfect order, deeply irritating.

The God Vessel, the Midnight Bloom, and the Dragon Blood fitting he believes are held by the Order of the Chains. He has not moved to take them because taking them would reveal his hand, would confirm to the Order that he has the Coccineum fragment, would accelerate their search for the Crimson Lily, and — most importantly — would not solve the Dragon Blood problem. A God Vessel with all four surviving components but no viable Dragon Blood produces an incomplete resonance field. He needs the blood.

Which brings him to the Dragonmaw Clan of the Ember Crown, whose existence Primus has known about for longer than the Order of the Chains has. He has been running probability calculations on the Primordial bloodline's survival for four hundred years. The Dragonmaw are the highest-probability result. He has not acted on this because acting on it requires either negotiation or coercion, and both carry variables he is still modeling.

He has offered governance to each of the surviving gods once. He will not offer it again. The next conversation will be a statement of terms, delivered through the Gate he is planning to reopen, by the first automaton to step through.

PART SIX: THE CURRENT STATE OF NYR THE THREE THREATS

Nyr stands at a crossroads that it did not choose and cannot avoid:

From Below, Panzuriel moves through whispers and strange metal, dismantling the world's institutions from the inside out. The Avatar of Myrkul's crown grows heavier. The armor passes between wearers, leaving ruin. And Panzuriel, patient and ancient, simply watches the accumulation of small collapses with the satisfaction of someone who knows that buildings fall faster than they rise.

From Beyond, Primus waits — which is more frightening than if he were moving. The Gate is closed, has been closed for centuries, but the glass-plain of the Muryland Peninsula still carries the resonance scar of the Eleven Months, and the automatons that stand

frozen across it are not as dormant as they appear. He has a Coccineum fragment. He is searching for the Crimson Lily. He has known about the Dragonmaw Clan's blood for longer than the Order of the Chains has. When he moves on the Dragon Blood — and the Order believes this is a question of when, not if — the race for all five components will stop being methodical and become something faster and far more dangerous to everyone in the Ember Crown's territory.

Within, the pantheon fractures. Without Myrkul, the balance has shifted. The Avatar walks the Astral beside the god's enormous cooling corpse and holds the death-domain together by sheer will and borrowed power, but

the Crown of Horns is not a god, and the domains of death and judgment require more than administrative competence. There are places in the Astral now where the judgment fails — where souls drift uncollected, lost in the silver void, becoming something they were not meant to become.

Sehanine moves through dreams and firelight, tracking the armor through its dream-residue, building a map of Panzuriel's intentions one whispered nightmare at a time.

Nyrissa watches everything and says very little, which everyone who knows her has learned to find deeply alarming.

A FINAL NOTE FROM THE COMPILERS

These records were assembled from sources that do not agree with each other on every detail. The Dream-Scrolls of the Moonbow Covenant describe Myrkul's last conversation differently from the Bone-Letters — in the Scrolls' version, his last word was not a confirmation but a question: "Was any of it mine?" Nyrissa's answer, in that version, is never recorded.

The discrepancy has not been resolved.

We suspect it was not meant to be.

First compiled in the 412th year of the Third Age, by the Vel'Kara Remembrance Society. Updated in the 498th year following the discovery of the automaton survey records at Fort Muryla. Amended most recently by an unknown hand, whose marginal notes appear in a script that several scholars have identified as consistent with the written form of Sehanine Moonbow's divine language — though none of them will say this in writing, because they know what it means that she has been paying attention.